



Who you are beyond what you do

The difference between your identity and your roles, and how you lost yourself along the way.

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This ebook is a self-knowledge and reflection resource. It does not replace therapeutic or psychological support. If you feel you have persistently lost your sense of self, please seek professional help.

1. When you stopped knowing who you are

There was a moment. You may not be able to point to it on a calendar, it may not have been a specific day, but there was a moment when you stopped knowing who you are.

Maybe it was when someone asked "what do you want?" and you went blank. Not from distraction. Not because the question was difficult. But because, genuinely, you didn't know. The question hung in the air, you looked inside yourself, and found silence. Not the good kind, the kind that comes from peace. The empty silence. The silence of a room that was once yours but is now full of other people's things.

Or maybe it was more subtle. Maybe it was that morning you looked in the mirror and didn't recognize yourself. Not physically. Physically it was you. But there was something in your eyes you no longer knew how to name. A tiredness that went beyond the body. A distance between you and yourself that can't be measured in miles.

Or maybe it was the day you happened to have a free afternoon. The kids were with their father, or with grandparents, or at school. The house was quiet. And you stood in the living room, staring at the walls, not knowing what to do with yourself. Not because there was nothing to

do. There was always something to do. But without anyone needing you, without a list, without a function, you felt strangely lost. As if, without the role, you didn't know where to place yourself.

And in that moment, even briefly, something passed through you. A thought that seemed to come from very far away, from a deep place you don't usually visit: "Who am I, really?"

If this is familiar to you, I want you to know: you are not alone. And you are not losing your mind. What you feel has a name, has a path, and has an explanation. And that is what we will talk about in these pages.

Because what happened to you, what is happening to you, is not a personal failure. It is the result of something that happens to many women, almost unnoticed. Something that settles in slowly, silently, while you are busy being everything others ask you to be.

You have been so many things. You have been a mother. You have been a wife, or a partner, or an ex-wife. You have been a daughter. You have been a professional. You have been a friend, a confidante, a shoulder, a safe harbor. You have been the one who solves, the one who organizes, the one who holds everything together, the one who cannot fall because if you fall, who picks up the pieces?

You have been all of this. Every day. Sometimes all at once. And somewhere, among all these versions of you that the world demanded, the version that is simply you was left behind. Not because you abandoned it on purpose. But because there was no space left. No time left. No energy left. And no one was asking about her.

No one asked what you wanted. They asked what was needed. No one asked how you felt. They asked if everything was taken care of. No one asked who you were. They asked what you did. And you, little by little, began to confuse the two.

You confused what you do with who you are. And when someone asks you to introduce yourself, what do you say? "I'm a mother of three." "I'm a teacher." "I'm a nurse." "I'm a stay-at-home mom." You define yourself by your function. Not by yourself.

And it's not your fault. Everyone does this. Our entire society teaches us to do this. From childhood, the question is "what do you want to be when you grow up?" and the answer is always a profession, never a way of being in the world. Nobody asks "what kind of person do you want to be?" Nobody asks "what makes you feel alive?" The question is always about the function, never about the essence.

And then we grow up and become walking functions. Mothers who function, professionals who function, wives who function. Everything functions. Except us.

The cruelest part is that this disappearance is applauded. The woman who gives herself up for her children is "dedicated." The one who sacrifices everything for the marriage is "generous." The one who works to the point of exhaustion is a "fighter." Society rewards you precisely for disappearing. And when you finally realize what happened, when you look inside and find silence where there should be a person, you feel ungrateful. Because you have everything. You have the house, the children, the job, the routine. What are you missing? You. You are missing.

And there is something nobody tells you: this emptiness is not a phase. It doesn't pass with vacation. It doesn't get resolved with a new hobby, or a new haircut, or yet another project. It's not boredom. It's a loss of contact. It's as if you've been living so far from yourself that you can no longer hear yourself when you call.

There are women who reach their forties, their fifties, and realize they've lived decades without consulting themselves. Without asking "is this what I want?" Without listening to themselves. Without choosing themselves. They lived inside the expectations of others, did what was

expected, followed the script that no one wrote but everyone knows, and when they finally stop and look inside, they find a stranger. Someone they don't recognize. Someone they don't know how to treat.

If this is what you feel, I want you to know: that stranger is you. And she is not angry. She is tired of waiting. She is ready to be seen. And the first step is the one you are taking right now: asking who you are beyond what you do.

Inside, something goes dark. Not overnight. Gradually. First you lose the small pleasures. You stop listening to the music you used to love. You stop reading what you used to read. You stop pursuing what brought you joy, because "now is not the time." Then you lose your opinions. When someone asks what you prefer, you say "either way," not from indifference, but because you genuinely no longer know. Then you lose the thread. You look back and can't remember who you were before you became all of this. And if you do remember, it seems like someone who lived in another life, in a story that no longer belongs to you.

I want to tell you something, and I want you to hold onto it as you read the rest of this book: the woman you were before you lost yourself has not disappeared. She did not die. She did not leave. She is there. Beneath the roles, beneath the functions, beneath the exhaustion. She is waiting. Not to be rescued. To be recognized.

This book is not about finding yourself in the romantic sense that magazines sell. It's not about "reinventing yourself" or "lighting your inner flame" or any of those promises that fit in an article title but don't fit in real life.

This book is about understanding what happened. How you got lost. Why you got lost. And what lies beyond the loss. I'm not going to give you a new identity. I'm going to show you that the one you have runs much deeper than what you do.

And perhaps, when you finish reading, you'll look at yourself with different eyes. Not the eyes of the mother, the professional, the wife, the daughter. With yours. Just yours.

2. Role is not identity

I'm going to ask you to do a mental exercise. You don't need paper or a pen. Just stop and think.

If tomorrow you stopped being a mother (not literally, of course, but if for some reason your children no longer needed you in that role), who would you be? If tomorrow you lost your job, or retired, or changed careers, who would you be? If your marriage ended, if you were alone, if everything that fills your days disappeared, what would remain?

If your first reaction to these questions is a tightening in your chest, a dizziness, a feeling that little or nothing would remain, then this chapter is for you.

Because what you're feeling is exactly the sign that you've confused your roles with your identity. And that confusion, however understandable and nearly universal, costs you more than you realize.

A role is a function. It's something you perform in a context. Mother is a role. Wife is a role. Professional is a role. Daughter is a role. Friend is a role. Caregiver is a role. Each of those roles demands different things

from you: skills, behaviors, availability, energy. Each has rules, expectations, schedules. And you perform them. Some more easily than others, but you perform them.

Identity is something else. Identity is who you are when you are not performing anything. It's what remains when you take off the costumes, when you close the doors, when no one is watching. It's your way of being in the world, not your function in the world. It's what you feel when you hear a song that moves you from within without knowing why. It's what you think when you look at the sky. It's what drives you, what outrages you, what makes you cry at movies, what makes you laugh alone. It's what no one can take from you because it doesn't depend on any external circumstance.

Identity doesn't change when the role changes. A woman who loses her job doesn't lose who she is. A woman whose children grow up and leave home doesn't lose who she is. A woman who divorces doesn't lose who she is. She loses a role. And if she confused the role with her identity, she feels she's lost everything.

This is why so many women enter crisis when a role changes. The mother whose children leave the nest feels empty. The woman who retires feels useless. The one who divorces feels lost. Not because life has

ended, but because the function has ended, and since the function was all she knew how to be, she feels she has ended.

There is a woman I'll call Isabel. Isabel was a nurse for thirty years. She enjoyed what she did, she was good at it, and everyone around her defined her by it. "Isabel is a nurse." "Isabel knows about these things." "Isabel, from the hospital." When she retired, in her early sixties, something strange happened. She began to feel anxious. Without reason. Without logic. She began to sleep poorly. She began to feel small, insignificant, as though she was no longer useful for anything. Her husband told her "now you can rest," but the rest was terrible, because without the uniform, without the shifts, without the patients, without the function, Isabel didn't know who she was. She didn't know what to do with herself. And the anxiety wasn't about retirement. It was about the emptiness. The emptiness of someone who had spent thirty years being a function and never invested in being a person.

Now think about something closer to you. Think about your day. How many hours of that day do you spend performing roles? Being a mother, a professional, a wife, a daughter, a household manager, a children's chauffeur, a cook, a home nurse, a conflict mediator, a family account-

tant? How many hours remain for you to simply be yourself? Without a function, without an obligation, without a label? For most women, the answer is zero. Or so close to zero it's nearly the same.

And when you spend the entire day being a function, your brain learns that you are the function. It's efficient, in a way. It doesn't need to spend energy asking "who am I?" It just executes. But the price is enormous. Because the day the function fails, or changes, or disappears, you're left without ground beneath your feet.

That's what happens when your children go to school and you stay home alone for the first time in years, and instead of relief, you feel panic. That's what happens when your partner says "you're not the same person anymore" and you think "I don't know which 'same' they mean." That's what happens when someone asks "how are you?" with genuine interest, and you don't know what to answer.

Because "how are you?" presupposes there is a "you" who is somehow doing. And when the "you" has been swallowed by roles, the question has no answer.

There is another danger in this confusion, and it may be the most silent of all: when the role fails, you feel that you have failed. Not the role. You.

When you shout at a child, you don't think "my performance in the role of mother was imperfect in this moment." You think "I'm a bad mother." When you can't solve a problem at work, you don't think "this task exceeded my current competencies." You think "I'm incompetent." When the marriage is in crisis, you don't think "the couple dynamic needs attention." You think "I failed as a woman."

The function failed. But since the function is you, you failed. All your value is anchored to the performance of roles. And since no role can be performed perfectly every single day (because you are human, not a machine), you live in a permanent sense of inadequacy.

"I'm not a good enough mother." "I'm not a good enough professional." "I'm not a good enough wife." And beneath all these phrases, the most terrible one: "I'm not enough."

But that phrase is a lie. The true phrase is: "I am not performing all my roles perfectly at the same time, which is humanly impossible." The difference between the two phrases seems subtle. But one destroys you. The other sets you free.

Because if the problem is that "you're not enough," there's no solution. You are you. You can't be more you than you already are. But if the problem is that you're trying to perform too many roles with impossible

perfection, that can change. Not because the roles disappear, but because your relationship with them changes. They stop being who you are and become something you do.

And that shift changes everything.

Because when the role is something you do, you can do it poorly on a bad day without that meaning you are bad. You can take the role off at the end of the day like removing a piece of clothing, and underneath, remain whole. You can lose a role without losing yourself.

And there is something particularly cruel in this dynamic: when you perform many roles at once, the roles conflict with each other. The mother wants to stay home with the sick child. The professional needs to go to the meeting. The wife wants to be present for her husband. The daughter needs to visit her mother. And you, caught between all these roles pulling in opposite directions, break apart. Not literally. But emotionally. You feel divided, fragmented, as if there are several people inside one body, and none of them is whole.

And the most perverse part is that, since you don't distinguish role from identity, every conflict between roles feels like a conflict within yourself. It's not the mother and the professional who are in conflict. It's

you who are in conflict with yourself. At least, that's how it feels. And this constant conflict, this feeling of never being whole anywhere, is one of the greatest sources of suffering for the women I know.

Right now, you may be wondering: "Okay, I understand the theory. But who am I, really, beneath the roles?" And if that question makes you uncomfortable, that's perfectly fine. It's normal. When you spend years not visiting a room, when you finally open the door, don't expect to find everything tidy. There is dust. There is darkness. There are forgotten things. But the room exists. And it's yours.

Before we go deeper, I need to tell you about something that Transpersonal Psychology invites us to consider: the possibility that there is a "self" beyond all roles, beyond the ego, beyond personal history. A "self" that doesn't need to prove itself, to justify itself, or to perform anything in order to exist.

3. The self beyond the ego

I'm not going to turn this chapter into a lecture. That's not my role here. But I need to tell you about something that, in my training in Transpersonal Psychology, changed the way I look at identity. And that may change the way you look at yours.

Conventional psychology (the kind we know best, the kind that appears in books, in articles, in conversations with a therapist) speaks a great deal about the ego. The ego is the part of you that knows your name, remembers your history, has opinions, preferences, fears. It's the part that says "I'm like this" and "I'm not like that." It's the part that compares, that competes, that defends itself, that builds a narrative about who you are.

The ego is not bad. It's necessary. You need it to function in the world. You need to know you are who you are, that you were born in a certain place, that you like certain things, that you hold certain values. The ego is your interface with the world. It's your calling card.

But the ego is not all that you are.

Transpersonal Psychology proposes something that, when you first hear it, might seem strange, but when you feel it, makes profound sense: there is a dimension of you that goes beyond the ego. Beyond personal history, beyond roles, beyond fears and achievements. A dimension that doesn't need to prove itself, that doesn't need validation, that doesn't depend on circumstances. That simply is.

I'm not talking about anything mystical, or religious, or esoteric. I'm talking about an observation that different traditions of thought, across centuries and distinct cultures, have made in different but converging ways: there is something in us that observes everything we live without being consumed by what we live. Something that remains when everything else changes.

Think about it: you have changed so much. The woman you were at twenty is not the woman you were at thirty. The woman you were at thirty is not who you are now. Your tastes changed, your opinions changed, your body changed, your relationships changed. Everything changed. And yet, there is something in you that remained. Something you recognize as "me," not the me that has this name, this profession, this face, but a deeper me. A me that looks at all those versions of you and recognizes them as its own, without being any one of them in particular.

That is the self beyond the ego. It's not an abstract idea. It's something you've already felt, even if you never gave it a name.

You felt it when you were in silence, perhaps in nature, perhaps looking at the sea, and something in you quieted so completely that for a moment you stopped being a mother, a professional, a wife, and you were simply presence. You didn't need to be anything. You didn't need to do anything. You existed, and that was enough.

You may have felt it in a moment of deep creativity, when you were so absorbed in something (painting, writing, cooking, singing, whatever it was) that you forgot yourself. Not "forgot" in the sense of neglect. "Forgot" in the sense that the ego, with all its worries and lists and comparisons, went quiet for a moment. And what remained was something vaster, lighter, more real.

You may have felt it in the moment you looked at your newborn child and something inside you opened in a way that doesn't fit into any role. It wasn't the role of mother you felt in that instant. It was something prior to the role. Something without a name, but more true than any name.

These moments are glimpses. Brief, fleeting, difficult to hold onto. But they are real. And they point to something important: you are not only your roles. You are not only your ego. You are not only your story. There is something more.

Now, I want to be very careful here, because this territory is easily distorted. There is a temptation (and it is a real temptation, one I see in many women who begin to explore these ideas) to use this notion of the "self beyond the ego" as an escape. "I am not my problems." "I am above all this." "My true self doesn't suffer." This has a name in psychology: spiritual bypassing. And it is as dangerous as any other form of avoiding pain.

Recognizing that there is a self beyond the ego does not mean ignoring the ego. It does not mean transcending pain, leaping over it, pretending it doesn't exist. It means you can be with the pain without being consumed by it. You can feel the fear without being the fear. You can live the roles without being the roles. Because there is something in you that is greater than all of it. Something that contains all of it without being defined by any of it.

It's the difference between the sky and the clouds. The clouds pass, change shape, sometimes darken the whole day. But the sky is always there. It doesn't fight the clouds. It doesn't try to push them away. It

simply is. And the clouds pass, because they always do.

Your roles are clouds. They matter. They are real. They bring joy and pain, meaning and exhaustion. But they are not the sky. You are the sky.

I know this can seem too beautiful to be useful. "All right, Vivianne, I am the sky. But the sky doesn't have to take three children to school at eight in the morning, or pay bills, or deal with a partner who doesn't help, or get through Sunday lunch with the in-laws."

And you are completely right. The practical life doesn't disappear because you hold this understanding. The roles are still there. The demands are still there. The exhaustion is still there. But something shifts. Something subtle yet profound. Because when you know that something in you doesn't depend on the roles, your relationship with the roles changes. You perform them with more ease, because you are no longer performing your existential survival. You are simply living.

You become less desperate when you fail in a role, because you know the role's failure is not your failure. You become less attached to perfection, because perfection is a demand of the ego, not of the deeper self. And you become more capable of saying "no," of resting, of withdrawing when you need to, because you no longer have to prove your existence through what you do.

This deeper self is what matters to us. It's what this book is about, even when it speaks of roles, of emptiness, of loss. Because all of that is a symptom of a disconnection: the disconnection from yourself. And reconnection doesn't happen by adding more roles, more things, more activities. It happens by stopping. By listening. By looking inward, to the place where silence lives. Not the empty silence of one who is lost. The full silence of one who is found.

But before we talk about the path back, we need to look squarely at something that frightens: the void. That void that appears when you stop functioning. The void that so many of us avoid at any cost. Because in the void is where the answer lives.

4. Why the void appears when we are only function

This is the central chapter of this book. If you are going to read only one, let it be this one. Because this is where the truth lives that so many of us avoid, and this is also where the door to something different lives.

I'll begin with a simple question: when did you last stop? Not stopped working to do something else. Not stopped running to tidy up. Not stopped taking care of others to take care of the house. Stopped. Doing nothing. Going nowhere. Not "making good use of time." Just still. Present. With yourself.

If the answer frightens you, if the idea of stopping makes you uncomfortable, if you feel that stopping is wasting time, throwing away hours, failing at the productivity of life, then this chapter is about you.

Because that fear of stopping isn't about time. It's about the void. It's about what appears when you strip away the layers of busyness and are alone with yourself. And what appears, for many women, is terrifying: nothing.

Not a peaceful nothing. A nothing that tightens the chest. A nothing that feels like a hole. A nothing that looks back at you and asks: "And now? Who are you without all of this?"

I know this nothing. And I know many women who know it.

Luísa was what everyone called an "amazing woman." She had three children, a demanding job, an impeccable house, she participated in the parents' association, organized dinners, did volunteer work on Saturdays. She was never still. Never. And when someone asked how she did it all, she smiled and said "it's a matter of organization." Inside, what she felt was something else: if I stop, I'll collapse.

And one day, she stopped. Not by choice. By exhaustion. Her body said enough in a way that couldn't be argued with: panic attacks, insomnia, a tiredness so deep she could barely get out of bed. And when she was finally still, when she could no longer function, the void came. An enormous, cold, frightening void. And Luísa realized, for the first time in decades, that she had absolutely no idea who she was without her functions. That everything she knew about herself was tied to a role. Without the roles, she was a stranger to herself.

Luísa's story is not unusual. It is the story of thousands of women. Women who function brilliantly until the day the body decides it won't function anymore. And when the body stops, the void appears. And the void, which until then was masked by agitation, reveals itself in its full extent.

But what is this void, really? I want you to understand this, because it changes everything: the void is not your absence. It is the absence of contact with yourself.

Think of it this way. You are there. You always were. But between you and yourself, layers have accumulated: obligations, roles, expectations, exhaustion, years. Layer upon layer. And when you finally stop and look inside, what you find is not you. It's the layers. And the layers feel like emptiness because they are not you, they are everything that has accumulated between you and yourself.

The void is not the problem. The void is the space between you and contact with yourself. And that space can be a crossing or a prison, depending on what you do with it.

Most women flee the void. And the most common way of fleeing is to fill it. Fill it with activity, occupation, noise, consumption, worry. If I'm always busy, I don't have to look inside. If I'm always solving other

people's problems, I don't have to face my own. If I'm always in motion, I don't have to feel what I feel when I'm still.

Do you recognize this? Do you recognize that impulse to fill every second? To reach for your phone the moment you're alone? To turn on the television when the house is quiet? To make a to-do list the moment your thoughts begin to wander? All of these are ways to flee the void. And the void pursues you, patiently, because it's in no hurry. It knows that one day you'll have to stop.

There are women who flee the void their entire lives. And what happens is this: they become ever more efficient, more occupied, more "present" in other people's lives, and ever more absent from their own. They function. But they don't live. And they reach the end of their days with the bitter feeling that they were there but weren't really there. That they did everything except exist.

Ana reached the age of fifty-two and her children left home. Both of them, within the space of a year. And when the door closed for the last time and she was alone in the house that for twenty-five years had been a permanent operations center, something passed through her that she hadn't expected: it wasn't grief. It was terror. Because without her children needing her, without the morning routines, the snacks, the baths, the school meetings, the arguments, the hugs, without all of that, Ana

felt she didn't exist. She didn't know what to do with her hands. She didn't know what to do with the day. She didn't know what to do with herself.

In the first few months, she tried to fill the space. She signed up for a gym, a ceramics class, a book club. She got a dog. She reorganized the entire house. But the void was there, beneath each activity, like water under ice. Thin, persistent, impossible to ignore for long.

Ana hadn't lost her children. She had lost the role of mother in the format she knew. And since that role had been everything she knew how to be, she lost herself.

There is another scenario that may feel closer to you. The woman who doesn't wait for her children to leave home to feel the void. The woman who feels it every day, at the end of the afternoon, when the noise settles and she is left alone with her thoughts. The woman surrounded by people, children, a husband, family, who still feels profoundly alone. Not because she is physically alone. Because she is emotionally without herself.

That loneliness in the middle of a crowd is perhaps the most painful of all. Because you cannot even name it without seeming ungrateful. "You have children, a husband, a job, a home, what are you complaining

about?" And you hear that, and you go quiet. And the void continues.

There is another profile I need to mention, because it is more common than one might think: the woman who has built everything around performance. The high achiever. The one who was always the best student, the best employee, the most competent, the most responsible. This woman built her identity not only on a role, but on excellence. And when excellence fails (and it does, because the human body was not made to perform at maximum capacity forever), the void appears with a particular violence. Because she doesn't know who she is without the function, and she also doesn't know who she is without success in the function. The fall is doubled.

And exhaustion (what is so often called burnout) is precisely this: the body refusing to continue functioning so that you can finally stop. Not weakness. The body's wisdom. The body knows what you don't allow yourself to know: that you cannot function indefinitely without asking what all this functioning is for.

And there is one more dimension that is rarely discussed: the woman who hasn't reached exhaustion, who hasn't had the visible crisis, but who lives in a kind of anesthesia. She is not unwell. But she's not well either. She doesn't suffer acutely. But she doesn't feel anything with intensity. She functions. She fulfills. She smiles when expected. But if

you ask her what she genuinely felt today, she struggles and finds very little. As if life were a sequence of tasks and she has been on autopilot for so long she no longer knows how manual mode works.

This woman doesn't go to the doctor because "there's nothing wrong." She doesn't seek help because "she's not in crisis." But she is lost. In a quiet, socially acceptable, invisible way. She is living without being. And the void, in this case, doesn't appear as anguish. It appears as indifference. As a "doesn't matter" that spreads over everything. And that indifference may be the most urgent signal of all, because it means the connection with yourself has grown so thin it can barely be felt.

Now I want to tell you the most important thing in this chapter. And I want you to hold it close.

The void is not the enemy. The void is the invitation.

Yes, it is uncomfortable. Yes, it is frightening. Yes, it feels like falling when you surrender to it. But the void you feel when you stop is not proof that you are nobody without your roles. It is proof that the roles occupied so much space they left you with no room to be someone.

It's like a room full of furniture you didn't choose. The room is yours, but you can't see it because it's too full. And when you begin to remove the furniture (the roles, the expectations, the obligations that don't really belong to you), what you find first is bare floor. And the bare floor seems sad. Seems meager. Seems insufficient. But it is on that floor that you can build something of your own. For the first time, perhaps, something truly yours.

The void is the space where identity can be born. Not the identity built on roles and functions, but the true identity. The one that doesn't depend on what you do, but on what you are.

The question is that almost no one teaches us to be in the void. They teach us to fill it. They teach us to flee it. They teach us to fear it. But no one teaches us to stay with it, to breathe inside it, to let it be what it is: a space of possibility.

And perhaps you're thinking: "That's very beautiful in theory, Vivianne. But in practice, the void is terrible. In practice, when I stop and am alone with it, I want to run."

I know. And I won't minimize that. The void is uncomfortable because within it live things that have been postponed for years. Emotions that were never felt. Questions that were never asked. Truths that were never

faced. "I'm not happy in this marriage." "I don't recognize myself in this life." "I don't know what I want." "I'm afraid of growing old without ever having lived for myself." These truths live in the void. And as long as you avoid it, they wait there.

You don't have to face everything at once. You don't have to plunge into the void without a safety net. But I want you to know that the void is not the end. It's the beginning. The beginning of a relationship with yourself that perhaps you've never had. Or that you once had, long ago, and let go.

And I want to tell you one more thing about the void, because it matters. The void is not uniform. It is not the same every day. There are days when it seems unbearable, and days when, if you stay quietly with it, it begins to transform. The silence that at first seemed dead begins to come alive. You start to hear things you didn't hear before. Not voices. Signals. Forgotten desires. Memories of who you were before you became everything you became. Fragments of yourself that remained beneath the layers and that now, in the silence, dare to appear.

It's like entering a house in the dark. At first, you see nothing. You're afraid. You stumble. You want to turn on the light or leave. But if you stay, your eyes adjust. And you begin to make out shapes. Contours.

Objects you recognize. And you realize the house wasn't empty. It was dark. And darkness is not the same as emptiness.

Your interior is not empty. It is dark. Because you spent years without lighting any light in there. And when you finally stop and stay still, the first impulse is to flee the darkness. But if you stay, if you let your eyes adjust, you begin to see. And what you see may surprise you. Because inside there is more than you thought.

And there are ways to begin that relationship. Not with grand gestures, not with dramatic decisions. With small glimpses. With moments when the true self, for an instant, breaks through the layers and appears. It is about those glimpses that we will speak next.

5. Glimpses of who you are

If I asked you to describe a moment when you felt completely yourself, without filters, without roles, without effort, would you have one? It doesn't need to be recent. It can be from years ago. From decades ago. But somewhere in your memory, there is such a moment.

Maybe it was by the sea. You were alone, or felt alone, and the sound of the waves was the only thing that existed. And for an instant, the briefest instant, you were not a mother, not a wife, not anyone. You were presence. You were breath. You were attention to the world with no filter in between. And it was good. So good it almost hurt, because you understood how much time you had spent away from that.

Or perhaps it was a night when you laughed. A real laugh, the kind that rises from deep within, that shakes the whole body, that makes you forget everything for a few seconds. And in that laughter there was a freedom you don't normally allow yourself. A freedom of being nothing but that laugh.

Or maybe it was while writing. Or painting. Or singing in the car, alone, with the music at full volume. Or cooking something for the sheer pleasure of it, without rushing, without the obligation to feed anyone, just

for the joy of creating with your hands. Or dancing. Running. Walking with no destination in mind.

Or perhaps, and this is harder to say, it was in a moment of pain. Because real pain also returns us to ourselves. When you cry deeply, when the weeping is so profound that it's no longer about the specific thing that caused it, there is a moment when you are simply feeling. Without a label, without a role, without performance. You are being human, in the rawest, most essential way. And that, strange as it may seem, is also a glimpse of who you are.

These moments have something in common: in them, the ego goes quiet. It doesn't disappear (you are alive, you are conscious), but it stops commanding. It stops comparing, judging, evaluating, measuring. And what remains is something simpler and more true.

Transpersonal Psychology calls this "being experiences," as opposed to "doing experiences." These are experiences in which you are not producing, functioning, performing. You are simply being. And in that "being" you find something of yourself that you find no other way.

The problem is that, in the life most of us live, these moments are extremely rare. And when they happen, we tend to devalue them. "Oh, I was distracted." "I drifted for a moment." "I wasn't doing anything use-

ful." As if the value of a moment depended on its usefulness. As if we only deserved to exist when we are being useful.

There is something I observe in many women who accompany me in this kind of reflection: when I ask them to describe a moment when they felt genuinely themselves, most describe a moment of solitude. Not sad solitude. Chosen solitude. A moment when they were alone, without obligation, without expectation, without an audience. And in that moment, something relaxed. Something opened. Something breathed.

And then, almost always, they add: "But it was so brief. And then I went back to reality."

I want you to reconsider what you call reality. Is "reality" the job, the house, the children, the bills, the obligations? Or is reality also that moment by the sea, that laugh, that instant when you existed without needing to justify yourself? Because if your definition of reality excludes the moments when you are most yourself, then your reality is incomplete. And it is a reality that excludes you.

These glimpses are not escapes. They are returns. They are moments when you return to yourself after having been away for so long. They are moments when the door to the room that is yours opens, briefly, and

you see what's inside. And what's inside is not emptiness. It's you.

There are signals in daily life that can help you recognize them. They are small, easy to overlook, but they are there.

When a scent transports you to a place you can't name, but that gives you a feeling of home. When a song makes you cry without knowing why, and the tears are not sadness, they are recognition. When you look at something beautiful (a tree, a light, someone's face) and feel a stillness that has no rush, no function, that serves nothing except to exist.

When you say something and think "this is me, this is true, this came from a place that has nothing to do with what's expected of me." When you refuse to do something and feel not guilt, but relief, a relief that comes from somewhere deep, as if your body is saying "finally."

These are the glimpses. They are windows that open. They are messages from your true self saying: I am here, you haven't forgotten me, I haven't forgotten you.

What we do with these glimpses is what matters. We can ignore them, devalue them, call them "moments of weakness" or "distractions." Or we can recognize them. We can look at them and say: "That was you. I recognize you. And I want you to come back."

And there is something more about these glimpses worth saying: they happen when you are not trying. No one feels deeply themselves through effort. You don't sit down and decide "now I'm going to be myself." That is the ego trying to control one more thing. The glimpses come when effort stops. When trying stops. When control stops. They come in moments of surrender, not of conquest. And this is profoundly counter-cultural, because we live in a culture that tells us everything is conquered through effort. But you don't conquer yourself. You already are. What you need is not effort, but permission. Permission to be without doing. Permission to exist without justifying yourself. Permission to be still without that meaning you are wasting time.

And there is a simple practice (not a technique, not a formal exercise, just a way of paying attention) that can help: notice what makes you feel alive. Not "happy" in the superficial sense. Alive. Awake. Present. That sensation of presence, of being entirely in a moment without wishing to be somewhere else, is your signal. It's your compass. It points to where you are.

It's not the same for every woman. For some it's nature, for others writing, for others movement, for others silence, for others a deep conversation with someone who truly sees them. There is no formula. There is attention. And attention is the first step toward reconnection.

But attention to what, exactly? To what you feel. To what your body tells you when you're not forcing it to perform a function. To what attracts you without reason. To what moves you without explanation. To what calls to you, quietly, beneath the noise of life.

These glimpses are proof that you exist beyond your roles. They are proof that the self that got lost beneath the layers is still there, whole, waiting to be seen. And when you begin to see it, even for moments, something changes. Not everything. Not suddenly. But enough to make you want the path back.

6. The path back to you

If you've made it this far, you now know some things you perhaps didn't know before.

You know that your roles are not your identity. You know that there is a self beyond what you do. You know that the void you feel is not a sign that you're nobody, it's a sign that the roles occupied too much space and left you with too little. You know there are glimpses, moments when your true self appears, briefly, as a reminder. And you know that those glimpses are real.

The question now is: how do you return? How do you come back to yourself when you've spent years, perhaps decades, living outward?

I'll offer you directions. Not detailed instructions. Not a ten-step program. Directions. Because the path back to yourself is not a generic path that works for everyone. It is a personal, intimate path, built to your measure, with your rhythm, your history, your wounds, your glimpses. I cannot trace it for you. But I can point to where it begins.

The first direction is to slow down.

Not to stop all at once. Not to drop everything. Slow down. Ease off the accelerator. Create, in your week, small spaces where you are not functioning. Spaces without an agenda, without a list, without a goal. Spaces in which you can simply be. It might be half an hour. It might be fifteen minutes. But let them be yours. Truly yours. Without the guilt of not being productive. Without the impulse to reach for your phone. Without the temptation to use that time to "do something useful."

Slowing down is radical in a culture that celebrates busyness. Saying "I have nothing to do this afternoon" is almost subversive. But it is in the "nothing to do" that you find yourself. Because in the "nothing to do," the ego has no script. And without a script, something else appears. Something spontaneous, something genuine, something yours.

The second direction is to listen to yourself.

Not listening to what guilt tells you, nor to what society expects, nor to what others need. Listening to yourself. What you feel. What you want. What bothers you. What does you good. What does you harm. What you say yes to when you wanted to say no. What you say no to when you wanted to say yes. Listening without judgment. Without self-criticism. Without "but I should." Just listen.

This is harder than it sounds. Because when you spend years ignoring yourself, your inner voice grows weak. It speaks softly. Sometimes it seems like it's not there at all. But it is. It's beneath all the noise. And if you give it space, if you give it attention, it begins to speak more clearly. At first, almost a whisper. "I don't like this." "I need to rest." "I want something different." Hear those whispers. They are the first signs that you are returning.

The third direction is to stop performing yourself.

This may sound strange, but hear me out. There are parts of your life where you are acting. Playing a character. Being who you think you should be instead of who you are. Laughing when you don't feel like it. Saying everything is fine when it isn't. Agreeing when you disagree. Swallowing your opinion to avoid conflict. Being pleasant when you're furious. Being available when you need to be alone.

This constant performance is exhausting. And it separates you from yourself. Every time you perform instead of being, you move another step away. And the path back involves beginning, slowly, carefully, to let the performance drop. Not in all places at once. Not dramatically. But in safe spaces, with safe people, start being truthful. Say what you feel. Ask for what you need. Show up as you are, without emotional makeup.

The fourth direction is to reclaim your body.

Because it's not only the mind that disconnects from you. The body does too. Many women who have lost themselves in their roles live "from the neck up." They function mentally. They manage, organize, plan, solve. But the body is just a vehicle. Not a home. Not a place of presence.

Reclaiming the body is going back to feeling it. Not through performative exercise (the gym to lose weight, running to be healthy), but through attention. Feeling your feet on the ground. Feeling your breath. Feeling the tension in your shoulders and letting it release. Feeling hunger, thirst, tiredness, without ignoring them. Feeling pleasure, the texture of your clothes, the warmth of the sun, the heat of the water in the shower. Coming back to the body is coming back to yourself. Because the body is where you live. And if you're not in your body, you're nowhere.

The fifth direction is to allow yourself not to know.

Not knowing who you are, for now, is legitimate. Not having the answers is legitimate. Being in process is legitimate. Our culture demands quick answers, clear definitions, stable identities. But real life doesn't work that way. True identity is not a fixed declaration. It's a ri-

ver. It moves, changes shape, finds new paths. And you can be in the river without knowing where it goes. You can say "I don't know who I am right now, but I'm on my way to finding out." And that phrase, spoken with honesty, is more true than any rigid definition of yourself.

These are directions, not the path. The path runs deeper. The path asks things of you that these pages cannot ask. It asks you to look at old wounds. It asks you to release beliefs you've carried for so long that you mistake them for truth. It asks you to allow yourself to be seen, not for what you do, but for what you are. And that kind of work, the work of going to meet yourself beyond the roles, beyond the layers, beyond the performance, is work that deserves company.

You don't have to do it alone. In fact, there are parts of this path that aren't done alone. Not because you're incapable, but because certain depths require a witness. They require someone to hold the space while you find yourself. They require a safe place where you can be vulnerable without it costing you.

And it is about that place that we'll talk in the next and final chapter.

7. The crossing that awaits you

I wrote this book because I believe one thing: understanding changes things. Not everything. But enough for the next step to become possible.

You now know that you didn't lose yourself through weakness. You got lost because you built your life on what you do, not on who you are. And when the roles occupied every space, you were left with no place in your own life. You know that roles are functions, not identity. You know there is a self beyond the ego, beyond performance, beyond exhaustion. You know the void you feel when you stop is not proof that you're nobody, it is the space where you can finally begin to be. You know there are glimpses, moments when your true self appears, brief but real. And you know there is a path back, made of slowing down, of listening, of truth, of presence in the body.

And perhaps, throughout these pages, something has begun to stir. Not a definitive answer. Not an instant transformation. But a recognition. The feeling that someone has named something you felt but couldn't

say. And that recognition, in itself, is already immense. Because what we name loses part of its power over us. What was confused becomes clearer. What was frightening becomes, at least, understandable.

But understanding is the first step, not the last.

The crossing back to yourself, the real crossing, the one that takes you not only to understand what happened but to live differently, that asks for more than words on a page. It asks for space. It asks for guidance. It asks for the kind of work that is done not with the head, but with the body, with the soul, with the parts of you that were silenced for so long.

That is why I created the Escola dos Véus.

Not as a course. Not as a content program to be consumed between tasks. But as a space of crossing. A place where women who have arrived where you have arrived (at recognition, at understanding, at the desire for something different) can take the next step. With accompaniment. With depth. With the respect this kind of work deserves.

The Escola dos Véus is where the work of discovering who you are beyond your roles is done. Not in theory. In practice. In lived experience. In the places where the mind doesn't reach and the body knows.

And if there is a part of you that wants not only to understand, but also to create, if there is a part of you that feels creative expression is one of the paths back to yourself, then Infonte may be your space. Infonte is where creativity and self-knowledge meet. Where what you discover about yourself can become language, image, form, word. Where creating is not performance, it is presence.

I'm not telling you that you need to go anywhere to find yourself. What you've read here is already yours. The seed has already been planted. And there are women who read these pages and from them begin their own path, at their own pace, with their own resources.

But if you feel it's the moment to go deeper, if you feel you can't reach where you want to go alone, if you feel that what you've read has opened a door and you want to walk through it with someone beside you, then the Escola dos Véus is waiting for you at escoladosveus.space. And Infonte at infonte.viviannedossantos.com.

Before you say goodbye to these pages, I want to ask you one thing. One small thing. I want you, today, at some point during the day, to ask yourself a question. Not the question "what do I have to do?", you already ask that hundreds of times. But this one: "What do I truly want, in this moment?"

You don't have to act on the answer. You don't have to change anything. Just listen. Just notice. Just give attention to what comes, without judgment, without criticism, without the urgency to transform what you feel into a task.

Maybe silence will come. Maybe an unexpected desire will come. Maybe tears. Maybe a brief clarity, like lightning. Whatever comes, it is yours. And it is true.

You are so much more than what you do. And even if you don't yet know exactly who you are beyond your roles, the fact that you are asking is already the beginning of everything.

With all my tenderness, *Vivianne*

This material is for self-knowledge and personal reflection. It does not replace therapeutic or psychological support. In situations of persistent suffering, intense emotional emptiness, depression, severe anxiety, or crisis, seek the support of a qualified mental health professional. Looking at yourself is the first act of courage. Asking for help is another.

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